

Feature Comparison

Audio Format	Near CD quality	CD quality	Sound quality At near CD quality (subjective)	Compression ratio at near CD quality	File Size for near CD quality (using MP3 as base)	Encoding speed (subjective)	Winamp support	Support in hardware devices	Compression type
MP3	128 Kbps	160/192 Kbps	Acceptable	11:1	1	Fast	Natively supported	Yes	Lossy
MP3PRO	64 Kbps	80/96 Kbps (max)	Acceptable	20:1	0.5	Fast	Plugin required	Limited	Lossy
WMA	48 Kbps	64/80 Kbps	Good	25:1	0.4	Fast	Natively supported	Yes	Lossy and Lossless
Ogg Vorbis	Quality level 3/4	Quality level 5	Good	14:1 (approximate)	0.8	Slightly Slow	Natively supported	No	Lossy
AAC	32/48 Kbps	96/128 Kbps	Good	30:1	0.3-0.4	Very Slow	Plugin required	Limited	Lossy

use dBpowerAMP for converting your CDs with a plugin. Hardware support too is a while away—rumours of portable players are in the air, but the format itself is yet to pick up.

The next note

MP3 may be aging, but development is still in progress to produce encoders that are leaner and produce better audio fidelity, with lesser audio artefacts. And it still

rules the P2P roost as the most traded commodity online. So while the MP3 standard cannot be discounted yet, the future of digital audio clearly belongs to other standards—WMA and Ogg Vorbis aim for top-of-the-line quality, while MP3PRO gives us small yet clear files. The crystal ball also shows the emergence of MPEG-4, bringing full-blown multimedia integration across the spectrum, not just bits and pieces.

Even with complex mathematical algorithms that accurately model the psycho-acoustic responses of that incredible human organ, the ear, and what you may hear about listening room tests, there is only one real testing ground: how good does your music sound when you play it on your computer? The human ear is the final judge of quality. 

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